

PARAGRAPH: Identifying the Tone

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What is "Tone"?

- The tone is the **author's attitude** or **emotion** toward the subject matter or the audience.

Do not confuse Tone with Mood.

- **Tone:** How the author feels (e.g., angry, sarcastic, critical).
- **Mood:** How the reader feels (e.g., scared, happy, suspenseful).
- **Shortcut:** If the option describes your feeling (e.g., "boring" or "frightening"), it is likely incorrect. Look for the author's stance.

The "Adjective Shortcut" Strategy

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The "Adjective Shortcut" Strategy

- The most effective way to identify tone is not to reread the whole passage, but to scan for adjectives and adverbs.
- These are the "feeling words."
- The Shortcut Steps:

Scan for Adjectives. **Ignore** the nouns (facts). ***Look at the descriptive words.***

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- Example:

"The catastrophic failure of the policy..."

(Tone: Critical/Negative)

VS.

"The unexpected outcome of the policy..."

(Tone: Objective/Surprised)

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- Identify the Polarity:
- Is the author Positive (+), Negative (-), or Neutral (0)?
- If the passage is purely factual (Neutral), eliminate all emotional options like "Angry" or "Ecstatic".
- Check the Ending:
- The concluding paragraph often holds the strongest clue to the final tone. Authors usually summarise their true feelings there.

Categorise Tones into Three “Buckets”

Bucket A: Neutral / Academic (Objective)

Used when the author is purely sharing facts without opinion.

- **Objective/Factual:** Unbiased reporting.
- **Descriptive:** Just painting a picture of a scene or person.
- **Analytical:** Breaking down a complex topic into parts (pros/cons) without taking a side.

Categorise Tones into Three “Buckets”

Bucket B: Negative / Critical

Used when the author is unhappy with the subject.

- **Acerbic/Vitriolic:** Harsh, stinging, and bitter criticism. (More intense than just "critical").
- **Cynical:** Believing the worst of human nature; doubtful that things will get better.
- **Sarcastic/Satirical:** Mocking something by saying the opposite of what is meant (often to expose stupidity).
- **Dogmatic:** Asserting opinions as if they were unarguable facts (arrogant).

Categorise Tones into Three “Buckets”

Bucket C: Positive / Emotional

Used when the author supports the subject.

- **Laudatory:** Praising or celebrating something.
- **Optimistic:** Hopeful about the future.
- **Nostalgic:** Longing for the past with affection.
- **Empathetic:** Understanding and sharing the feelings of others.

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

Topic: Government's New Policy

Example 1:

"The new policy introduced by the Minister aims to reduce inflation by 2%. While proponents argue it will stabilise the market, economists warn that it may temporarily increase unemployment. Data from the last quarter suggests a mixed reaction from the stock market."

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

Topic: Government's New Policy

Example 1: Analytical Tone

"The new policy introduced by the Minister aims to reduce inflation by 2%. While proponents argue it will stabilise the market, economists warn that it may temporarily increase unemployment. Data from the last quarter suggests a mixed reaction from the stock market."

Explanation: The author presents both sides ("proponents argue", "economists warn") and cites data. There is no personal emotion.

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

Topic: Government's New Policy

Example 2:

"Once again, the Minister has embarrassed himself with a policy that is as shortsighted as it is destructive. This catastrophic attempt to fix inflation is nothing more than a desperate grab for votes, leaving the poor to suffer while the wealthy applaud."

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

Topic: Government's New Policy

Example 2: Acerbic/Critical Tone

"Once again, the Minister has embarrassed himself with a policy that is as shortsighted as it is destructive. This catastrophic attempt to fix inflation is nothing more than a desperate grab for votes, leaving the poor to suffer while the wealthy applaud."

Explanation: Words like "embarrassed," "shortsighted," "destructive," and "desperate grab" show strong, bitter disapproval.

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

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Example 3: *“Oh, brilliant! Another 'masterstroke' from our genius administration. I am sure that raising taxes on the poor is the perfect way to make everyone rich. Truly, their wisdom knows no bounds.”*

3 examples of the same topic in different tones

Topic: Government's New Policy

Example 3: Satirical Tone

"Oh, brilliant! Another 'masterstroke' from our genius administration. I am sure that raising taxes on the poor is the perfect way to make everyone rich. Truly, their wisdom knows no bounds."

Explanation: The author calls it "brilliant" and a "masterstroke," but clearly means the opposite. The exaggeration signals **satire**.

Confusing Pairs

Cynical vs. Sceptical:

A **Sceptical author** doubts the truth (needs proof).

A **Cynical author** doubts the motive (thinks everyone is selfish).

Objective vs. Subjective:

Objective is fact-based (Encyclopedia).

Subjective is opinion-based (Editorial).

Apathetic vs. Neutral:

Neutral means not taking a side.

Apathetic means not caring at all (indifferent).

Let's Check!

1. What is the tone of the passage?

"The **recent study** on urban migration patterns reveals a shift in demographic trends. While **60%** of the rural population previously moved to metropolitan hubs for employment, **recent data indicates a 15% decline** in this movement **over the last fiscal year**. **Sociologists attribute** this reverse migration to the rising cost of living in tier-1 cities and the simultaneous improvement of digital infrastructure in semi-urban areas. **However, long-term economic impacts remain to be seen as the data is still preliminary.**"

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"It is truly heartwarming to see the sheer brilliance of our city planners. Who else but a genius would decide to repair all four major highways simultaneously during peak tourist season? One must admire the dedication required to ensure that every single commuter spends their entire morning contemplating the meaning of life while stuck in a gridlock. Their foresight is, quite frankly, staggering."

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A. Acerbic B. Commiserating C. Satirical D. Laudatory (praise)

The author uses words like 'genius' and 'brilliance,' but describes a terrible situation (traffic jams). When the words praise, but the reality is bad, what is the specific literary term?

Commiserate: Express pity, sympathy, etc.

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"The ancient library of Alexandria was not merely a collection of scrolls; it was a beacon of human aspiration. Standing amidst its hallowed halls, one would have felt the electric charge of discovery, the quiet hum of scholars translating the cosmos into ink. It was a testament to the insatiable human hunger for knowledge, a glorious monument that, though lost to the sands of time, continues to ignite the imagination of every seeker of truth."

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"The committee's refusal to address the climate crisis is not just a failure of policy; it is a moral bankruptcy. They hide behind bureaucratic jargon and hollow promises while the world burns. Their cowardice is palpable, and their continued inaction is a direct assault on the future of every child on this planet. It is a shameful display of negligence that history will not forgive."

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